

Debian 7.0 'Wheezy' released

To all those Debian fans who have been patiently waiting for the latest version of their favourite distro, the wait is finally over! The much-awaited Debian 7.0 'Wheezy' is out! The new stable version of Debian comes with some really interesting features including "... multiarch support, specific tools to deploy private clouds, an improved installer, and a complete set of multimedia codecs and front-ends, which remove the need for third-party repositories."

The announcement about the release was made in a blog post of the Debian Project team. Elaborating on the multiarch support introduced in Debian 7, the post said, "Multiarch support, one of the main release goals for Wheezy, will allow Debian users to install packages from multiple architectures on the same machine. This means that you can now, for the first time, install both 32- and 64-bit software on the same machine and have all the relevant dependencies correctly resolved, automatically."

The installation process of Debian 7 has been simplified further. The software can now be installed using software speech, which can help the visually impaired who do not use a Braille device, in a significant way. The installation system is available in 73 languages, and more than a dozen of them are available for speech synthesis too. In addition, for the first time, Debian supports installation and booting using UEFI for new 64-bit PCs (amd64), although there is no support for 'Secure Boot' yet.

Mozilla rolls out Firefox 21, making it available for download

For all those Firefox fans out there, the latest version of the browser is available for you to download. Firefox 21, the latest open source browser, is available for download via Mozilla's FTP servers.

Windows users can access the US English version of the 32-bit installer folder and download the Firefox Setup 21.0.exe file for their PCs. For all those waiting for official news on the browser, keep a close watch on Mozilla's website for an update.

You can get a fair idea of what Firefox 21 offers if you look at its beta release notes. Some of the features include an improvised three-state-UI for 'Do Not Track'. This means Firefox has now put the mechanism of auto-suggest in place, with which the browser will suggest how to improve application start-up times. The browser maker has reportedly used FHR (Firefox Health Report) to improve performance, fix problems and allow users to see how their browsing experience on this version of Firefox compares against earlier versions of it.

Mozilla has also included some graphics-related performance improvements and bug fixes in the new browser version. Users can also find out the system requirements for running Firefox 21 from Mozilla's official website. This is the desktop version of the browser, which will soon be followed by its mobile variant.



NASA PCs in space to run Debian Linux!

Linux has finally reached space, with NASA adopting it for the laptops in the International Space Station (ISS). In addition, the first humanoid robot in space, named R2, is powered by Linux.

This news was shared by Keith Chuala, a contractor at the United Space Alliance, which manages the Space Operations Computing (SpOC) for NASA, and leader of the ISS's Laptops and Network Integration Teams. These computers that are used by ISS astronauts will run Debian 6. Earlier, Scientific Linux, a clone of Red Hat Enterprise Linux (RHEL) was being used for these computers.

While Linux has been on the scene at the ISS ever since it was launched, it was earlier only used for NASA's ground operations and never for the computers in space.

OpenStreetMap releases new map editor

The OpenStreetMap (OSM) project has released its new map editor for those who contributed in the creation of the latest version. The map editor was first showcased back in February 2013, and after a long wait the release is finally out.

The new iD editor has been developed with funds from the Knight Foundation and, interestingly, it does not require Flash to run, which is a refreshing change from the previous ones. The tool has been written completely in HTML5 and uses the D3 visualisation library.

The Foundation hopes that the new map editor will enable them to involve more contributors for the crowd-sourced mapping service. Apart from launching the editor, the Foundation has also introduced a funding appeal to raise money for new hardware for its set-up.

